# Los Angeles Times

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JAE C. HONG Associated Press

**HOMELAND** Security Investigations officers leave a home in Commerce after arresting a suspect Monday.

# California voter fraud suspects puzzled by arrest

Some defendants who appeared in court say they don't remember registering to vote.

BY BRITTNY MEJIA AND KEVIN RECTOR

At the federal courthouse in downtown Los Angeles late Monday, several green card holders arrested in a crackdown on alleged California voter fraud expressed confusion over the charges — with some saying they had no recollection of registering to vote, as Trump administration officials accuse them of doing.

Among them was Ana Domínguez, 60, a native of El Salvador living in Long Beach as a lawful permanent resident. Federal authorities accused her Monday of fraudulently registering to vote in July 2006 and then lying about it in her naturalization paperwork in March 2026.

Domínguez said she did not have any memory of registering to vote.

Another man accused of the same crimes as Domínguez said the same: He wasn't aware of ever registering to vote, as federal prosecutors claimed he had.

Both were among the 28 people charged with federal election-related crimes Monday, including fraudulent voter registration and making false statements in a naturalization application. Federal prosecutors and high-ranking Justice Department officials had touted the arrests during a news conference hours before as proof that California elections are corrupted by noncitizen voters — as President Trump has long alleged.

For those charged in the Central District of California, voter registration and public records showed at least two individuals who shared the names of defendants were registered to vote as Republicans, two as Democrats, two as supporters of the Peace and Freedom Party and three with no party preference chosen.

State officials said the isolated instances of noncitizens voting, if accurate, are not evidence of widespread voter fraud. They also raised questions as to whether the charges could be trusted to be accurate, citing similar accusations being disproved elsewhere in the country.

Election experts have said many instances of non-citizens registering to vote are a result of administrative error or confusion on the part of the immigrant — not intentional criminality.

"We know from past experience that sometimes people register to vote accidentally, as when there is a mistake at the DMV," Rick Hasen, director of the Safeguarding Democracy Project at UCLA School of Law, wrote Monday in a blog post. "There is only a crime if the

[See **Defendants,** A7]

# FEDS ARE LOOKING AT 17,000 OTHERS ON ROLLS

BY KEVIN RECTOR

Federal authorities this week teased a "separate batch" of 17,000 potential noncitizen voters in their federal court challenge to California's handling of alleged voter fraud.

In response, Los Angeles County officials questioned the accuracy of the government's earlier list of 20,000 alleged noncitizen voters — saying a preliminary review of a subset of those voters found evidence that nearly 40% were born in the U.S.

The claims came in filings shedding new light on the unprecedented Homeland Security inquiry into California's voter rolls just weeks before the Nov. 3 election.

On Monday, Nicolas Bartell, a Homeland Security official, wrote in a sworn affidavit that — in addition to developing the disputed list of 20,000 "likely noncitizen" voters at the heart of the litigation — his agency has also developed a "separate batch of more than 17,000 voting records potentially tied to noncitizens."

"Our review is ongoing as USCIS receives records on a rolling basis before the election date," wrote Bartell, the associate director of the Fraud Detection and National Security Directorate at U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services.

On Tuesday, Monica Flores, a top official in the L.A. County Registrar-Recorder/County Clerk's office, wrote in an affidavit that staff members had reviewed a sample of 200 registrations from the list of 20,000 voters who the Justice Department

[See **Voters,** A7]

### Giving the lie to Trump's claims

Only 28 suspects in California? That's not rampant fraud, Anita Chabria writes. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

# Climate forecast grim for SoCal beaches

State assessment predicts oceanfront cliffs will retreat as temperatures rise.

BY BLANCA BEGERT

As ocean levels rise, waves crash farther inland and the coast continues to crumble, Southern California is on track to lose 30% to 70% of its beaches over the next several decades. Almost half of all beach cliffs are likely to retreat by 30 to 80 feet by 2100. And a 1.6-foot increase in sea level rise by 2060 will leave low-lying coastal areas including the ports and Santa Monica, Venice and Redondo beaches particularly vulnerable to floods and storms, with one estimate predicting 15,000 people exposed in Los Angeles County.

Those are just some of the dire findings in California's Fifth Climate Change Assessment, a state-commissioned report that comes out every several years and details how climate change is expected to affect everything from public health to animal habitat to central touchstones of the California way of life.

"There are things in there that are hard to digest, and hard to wrap our heads around," said Abby Edwards, senior deputy director for the Governor's Office of Land Use and Climate Innovation, which led the assessment. "I just hope that this can be a call to action to make sure we are still really doubling down on all of our climate mitigation goals."

The report updates the picture for California's hotter future with a projected 4-degree Fahrenheit increase in average temperatures and 50% longer heat waves by the middle of the century. Even more warming is expected farther inland where temperatures are already

[See **Climate,** A8]

# Battered Long Beach braces for more damage

**By Fedor Zarkhin**

Long Beach's peninsula is a narrow spit of land that juts out between Alamitos Bay and the Pacific Ocean. Over the years, its tiny beach cottages were replaced by multistory homes and apartments with sweeping views of the water.

It can seem a precarious spot. But Long Beach residents have long felt protected from the storms of the ocean by a vast breakwater constructed about 80 years ago to give the Navy safe harbor close to shore. The breakwater now serves as protection for Long Beach harbor, one of the largest ports in the world.

Except there is a weakness.

When it was constructed, the breakwater was built far enough east to protect the shore from waves coming from the west, but left a gap that allowed waves coming from the south to hit a narrow stretch of Long Beach's Alamitos Peninsula. That means that in the summer, when tropical storms whip up winds and waves traveling north, a small stretch of the peninsula gets the full brunt of those waves.

The result has left the peninsula vulnerable to the fury of El Niño. Several homes facing the Pacific are being broken apart by months of high surf and powerful waves. The historic wooden boardwalk has splintered. And residents and city officials fear things will get a lot worse as "super El Niño" conditions peak this winter.

This week, the

[See **Peninsula,** A8]



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

**A CREW** installs wood to shield a home on Long Beach's peninsula Sept. 23.

# Becerra's bumpy final ascent

The onetime 'rising star' lost some shine in D.C. climb

BY BEN WIEDER

WASHINGTON — Xavier Becerra was dubbed a "rising star" before he even entered the halls of Congress.

His June 1992 Democratic primary victory over Los Angeles school board member Leticia Quezada in California's 30th Congressional District earned the 34-year-old candidate that description in The Times.

When the boyish, affable congressman became the first Latino lawmaker appointed to the powerful House Ways and Means Committee in his second term, national outlets took notice.

Thirty years later, in the final weeks of his gubernatorial race with Republican Steve Hilton, Becerra now finds himself poised to lead the most populous state in the country.

An examination of Becerra's more than 25 years in Washington shows a politician who was skilled at building important alliances and amassing power on Capitol Hill, but had some stumbles along the way and faced criticism for his performance in his highest-profile role.

Becerra built his reputation as a diligent consensus-builder — a workhorse rather than a show horse, to use an analogy favored by political scientists — but also revealed himself to be an ambitious political operator in key moments.

"He's an affable person who's not afraid to pull out a knife in politics while smiling," said Christian Grose, a political science professor at USC.

Becerra's campaign declined to comment on his time in Washington.

Becerra's origin story traces back to his youth in Sacramento, and a moment when a high school friend was about to throw out a

[See **Becerra,** A14]

# AI pricing tools hit nerve with shoppers

BY DEE-ANN DURBIN AND ANNE D'INNOCENZIO

Consumers aren't just frustrated with high prices. They're angry and confused about the increasingly high-tech ways that restaurant chains and major retailers are setting those prices.

Digital price tags are rapidly replacing paper ones in grocery aisles. Artificial intelligence tools help businesses decide what to charge by predicting how customers might respond. Terms like "dynamic pricing" and "surveillance pricing" are stirring anxiety on social media, where users wonder whether different people are getting different prices for the same product.

Americans have grown accustomed to changing prices when booking flights, hotel rooms and rides, but the prospect of everyday spending shaped by algorithms they don't understand and personal data they may not realize they're sharing has touched a nerve.

"There are major tensions happening right now between who's really going to have the power with some of these algorithms and usage of bots and AI: the companies or the shopper," said Katie Thomas, who leads an internal consumer behavior think tank at the management consulting firm Kearney.

Companies using the technology say some concerns stem from misconceptions about how their pricing tools work. Walmart Chief Executive John Furner said in a blog post last month that digital price tags save workers time and keep prices up to date. He said the labels aren't used to raise prices based on the weather,

[See **Pricing,** A11]



ADAM PANTOZZI NBAE via Getty Images

### CENTER STAGE

Walker Kessler has a prominent role as Lakers' big man. The 7-foot-2 newcomer banks on his competitiveness to handle pressure. **SPORTS, B10**

### Separatist bid fails in Alberta

Three-quarters of voters in referendum favor remaining in Canada, a big win for Carney. **WORLD, A3**

### More Medicaid funds withheld

Trump administration is deferring $1.2 billion in reimbursements to California. **NATION, A4**

**Weather**
A shower and T-storm. L.A. Basin: 73/61. **B6**

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